Colonization by Europe

During the 19th century, Africa went through significant change. It experienced famine, disease and power struggles among the ruling class. African leaders made alliances with merchants and missionaries from Europe to accomplish their own goals and ambitions. The Europeans took advantage of these alliances to later conquer the territories in Africa.

During the first years of the century, Europe had little knowledge about the African region. The Europeans focused on trading along the coast while African and Arab merchants handled the domestic goods and slaves. By the end of the century, Europe had succeeded in executing a consistent colonization plan which had its peak in the 1880's.

In 1807, with the British abolition of slave trade, the British navy began patrolling the African coasts and intercepting any other nation's slave ships. European oppression continued in the last two decades of the century when conflicts and rivalries between the continents began to significantly impact the people living there. During the 1880's, European powers divided the African territory among themselves seemingly not aware of how much land they had taken without the consent of the inhabitants.

When the First World War occurred in 1914, the African people played a major role and helped the Allied Powers. As we mentioned before, the early European expeditions to Africa consisted of colonizing uninhabited islands or establishing coastal ports as a base of trade. During these first years, the European interest in Africa was strictly commercial and economical as they focused on making trading routes.

However, a major European intervention occurred in Africa in the 19th century. The moment is known as "Scramble for Africa" because the leading European powers divided the African land amongst themselves. This scramble took place at a conference in 1884 where the main countries in Europe established international guidelines for the acquisition of African territory. The conference formalized what is now known as “New Imperialism.” Europe added to its territory almost 9 million square miles of